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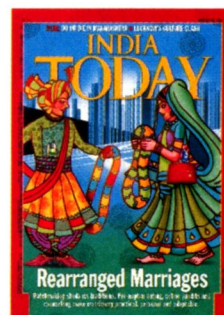
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No other invention in contemporary history has changed our world as much as the Internet. It has transformed the way we work, play and communicate. Perhaps the most significant change it has wrought is to bring people from different continents together. That is also what has created one of the major detours of the information highway: matrimonial sites. In India, where matrimony has always been a huge industry, the arrival of marriage sites is a major development. For young urban Indians, the convenience of the Net where they can conduct a conversation to assess each other is impossible to resist. A recent survey found that these sites have over 12 million users, or 48 per cent of the Indian online population uses the Net for matrimonial purposes.

One of the leading matrimonial sites touched the one million mark in success stories last year. It gets an average of 50 testimonials every day from happy couples. The boom in Netrimony and the success ratio also signifies changes in Indian society. Over 30 per cent users come from smaller towns, cover a range of occupations and, most significantly, use the Net to meet like-minded people and only then do they bring in the parents. The growing numbers also point to a new mindscape. A new survey across urban India shows that for 46 per cent men and women, matching horoscopes with prospective life partners is irrelevant; 51 per cent vote for inter-caste marriage; 61 per cent men want women with advanced degrees and 48 per cent prefer working wives. The youth today are asserting personal choice and want someone compatible as opposed to arranged marriages where the couple meet on the wedding day.



Our Oct '04 cover

Our cover story looks at the boom in online matrimony and the changes it is bringing about among young urban Indians and their parents. We also look at the business of online matrimony and the people behind them. Finally, we asked Assistant Editor Priya Sahgal, highly eligible and of marriageable age, to register herself on one of the major websites and see for herself how Netrimony works. As she says: "It has all the perks of a blind date except that neither of you is blindfolded."

In this issue we also carry exclusive extracts from *My Country, My Life*, L.K.Advani's autobiography, the most important political biography in recent years. For the first time we get his version of the truth on issues that changed the course of Indian politics: the Emergency, the destruction of the Babri Masjid, the BJP in power, the Kandahar hijack, the Agra summit, Gujarat riots, his controversial statements at Jinnah's mausoleum in Pakistan and the fallout, plus his views on his political contemporaries.

This is a mammoth attempt by one of India's most misunderstood politicians to redeem himself. The man who could be the next prime minister has an interesting story to tell about himself.

Aaron Purie
(Aron Purie)